

WILTING OF WORDS

A Novel

by Pratyay Saha

Some words fade with time.

Others wait for someone to carry them.

TECHNODEF

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WILTING OF WORDS

A Novel

Written by Pratyay Saha

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First Edition — 2026

Published independently by Pratyay Saha
under the imprint **TechnoDef**

Available in digital edition through **Amazon Kindle**.

Copyright Proprietor: Pratyay Saha

Publishing Imprint: TechnoDef

Country of Publication: India

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DEDICATION

*For everyone who has ever felt unheard,
for every voice that struggled to find a place,
for every dream that was told to be too large,
and for everyone who discovered that sometimes,
a single page can become the beginning of something greater.*

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I

The House of Unspoken Things

Chapter 1

The Colour of Morning

The first thing Aratrika learned about mornings was that they had colours.

Not the colours people painted on walls.

Not the colours printed in school textbooks.

Real colours.

Morning sunlight was pale gold when it entered through the eastern window. The sky was almost white before sunrise and became blue only after the neighbourhood had begun to wake. The old curtains in her room were brown, but when sunlight passed through them, they appeared almost orange.

Aratrika noticed these things because she had nowhere else to put her attention.

She was fourteen.

Fourteen was supposed to be an age of school uniforms, examinations, friendships, silly arguments and dreams that changed every few weeks.

But inside her house, dreams were considered luxuries.

Especially for girls.

She sat beside the window with an open notebook.

The first page was blank.

She liked blank pages.

Nobody had yet told them what they were supposed to become.

Outside, a vegetable seller called out to the early morning neighbourhood. Somewhere a bicycle bell rang twice. A bus groaned along the main road.

Aratrika dipped her pen into the ink.

Then she wrote:

Some people are born into houses.

Some people are born into expectations.

She stopped.

She read the two sentences again.

Then she scratched out the second one.

She wrote:

Some houses have walls.

Some houses have rules.

That sounded better.

She smiled.

It was a very small smile.

But it belonged entirely to her.

“Aratrika!”

Her mother's voice came from the corridor.

She closed the notebook immediately.

“Coming.”

She slid it beneath her schoolbooks.

That notebook was not a diary.

At least, she did not call it one.

A diary was something private.

This was different.

This was where she kept the things she could not say.

There were sentences about school.

Sentences about her teachers.

Sentences about books.

Sentences about the way people looked at one another.

And sometimes sentences about herself.

Those were the most dangerous ones.

Because whenever Aratrika wrote about herself, she began asking questions.

And questions were not always welcome in her house.

At breakfast, the television was playing the morning news.

Her father sat at the table reading a newspaper.

Her mother was preparing tea.

Aratrika stood quietly near the doorway.

“You’re late,” her father said.

“Sorry.”

“You have school.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you standing there?”

She sat down.

Nobody spoke for several seconds.

Her father turned a page.

“Examinations are coming.”

“Yes.”

“Your cousin got very good marks last year.”

Aratrika nodded.

“Study properly.”

“Yes.”

That was how most conversations about her future happened.

Short sentences.

Instructions.

Comparisons.

Expectations.

Never questions.

Nobody asked what she wanted to become.

Perhaps they assumed a girl did not need such a question.

Perhaps they thought the answer would not matter.

Aratrika did have an answer.

She wanted to write.

She wanted to speak.

She wanted to stand somewhere someday and make people listen—not because she was loud, but because what she said mattered.

She had never said this aloud.

Instead, she took another sip of tea.

The newspaper rustled.

Her father looked at her.

“Why are you always writing?”

Aratrika froze.

“Nothing.”

“I have seen your notebooks.”

“They’re school notes.”

“Then study from them.”

“Yes.”

He returned to the newspaper.

The conversation was over.

But Aratrika’s heart continued it.

Why is writing considered useless?

Why is studying only valuable when it produces marks?

Why does everyone ask what I scored but nobody asks what I thought?

She looked down at her plate.

She knew better than to ask.

So she ate quietly.

At school, things were different.

Not completely different.

But enough.

The school corridor was loud with footsteps, conversations and laughter.

Aratrika liked it.

Here, people were allowed to be unfinished.

A student could make a mistake in mathematics.

Someone could forget a poem.

Someone could answer a question incorrectly.

Someone could laugh too loudly.

The world did not end.

She entered her classroom and took her usual seat.

On the blackboard was written:

CLASS X — YOUR FUTURE BEGINS NOW

Aratrika stared at the sentence.

She wondered whether futures really began in classrooms.

Or whether they began much earlier.

Perhaps hers had begun the first time somebody told her she could not do something.

Perhaps everyone's future began with a sentence someone else had spoken about them.

She opened her textbook.

The teacher entered.

“Good morning.”

The class stood.

“Good morning, ma'am.”

“Sit down.”

Chairs moved.

Books opened.

Pens clicked.

And another ordinary school day began.

Aratrika did not know that before the year ended, her marks would become a number people remembered.

She did not know that her name would one day appear in places she had never imagined.

She did not know that one day strangers would read the words she was hiding beneath her schoolbooks.

She certainly did not know that her notebook would outlive her.

For now, she was simply a fourteen-year-old girl sitting in Class X, listening to a lesson while secretly writing a sentence in the margin of her notebook:

If nobody gives you a voice, perhaps you have to write one.

She underlined it once.

Then twice.

And closed the book.

Chapter 2

A House Full of Mirrors

Aratrika's house had mirrors everywhere.

There was one in the bedroom.

One in the hallway.

One beside the front door.

And a small one in the bathroom.

Her mother liked mirrors.

“People should always look presentable,” she often said.

Aratrika wondered why being presentable mattered so much.

At school, nobody cared whether her hair was perfectly arranged when she was answering a difficult question.

Nobody cared about her appearance when she was reading aloud.

Nobody cared about how she looked when she solved a difficult mathematics problem.

Yet at home, appearance somehow entered every conversation.

“Look at yourself.”

“Why don't you take better care of yourself?”

“Don't go outside looking like that.”

The comments were rarely dramatic.

That was what made them difficult.

They were small.

Repeated.

Ordinary.

A sentence here.

A comparison there.

A remark disguised as advice.

Over time, they became walls.

Aratrika began avoiding mirrors.

Not because she hated herself.

Because she was tired of being told how she was supposed to see herself.

One afternoon, she stood before the hallway mirror.

She looked at her reflection.

For a few seconds, she said nothing.

Then she took out her notebook.

She wrote:

Perhaps the cruelest mirror is the one other people hold in front of you.

She stared at the sentence.

This time, she did not cross it out.

That evening, rain began falling.

Aratrika sat near the window.

She watched water gather on the glass.

The neighbourhood blurred.

Lights became golden circles.

People hurried home.

She opened her notebook.

For the first time, she wrote a paragraph instead of a sentence.

She wrote about a girl who lived in a house where everyone told her what she looked like.

The girl believed them.

Then one day she stopped looking into mirrors.

Instead, she looked into books.

And books showed her something mirrors never had.

Possibilities.

Aratrika stopped writing.

She read the paragraph again.

Then she added one final line:

She did not need to become beautiful. She needed to become free.

The rain became heavier.

Aratrika smiled.

This was why she wrote.

Not because she believed every sentence she wrote was good.

Not because she expected anyone to read it.

She wrote because paper never interrupted her.

Paper never laughed.

Paper never compared her.

Paper simply waited.

And sometimes waiting was the beginning of being heard.

The next morning, the rain had stopped.

Drops of water clung to the leaves outside the window. The road was still wet, reflecting the pale morning sky.

Aratrika packed her schoolbag.

Before leaving, she looked at the notebook beneath her books.

She hesitated.

Then she took it out and opened to the previous night's writing.

For a moment, she wondered whether she should tear the page out.

Nobody would ever know.

She could destroy the words before they became evidence of thoughts she had never spoken aloud.

Her fingers touched the corner of the page.

Then she stopped.

“No,” she whispered.

It was the first time she had ever defended something she had written.

She closed the notebook.

She put it back into her bag.

And walked out of the room.

At school, the morning assembly had already begun.

Aratrika joined her classmates at the back of the line.

The principal was speaking about discipline.

“Your school years are the foundation of your future,” he said.

“What you do today will shape who you become tomorrow.”

Aratrika listened carefully.

She liked the idea.

But she wondered whether a person's future could really be built only from marks, uniforms and examination results.

The national anthem began.

Everyone stood straight.

Aratrika looked toward the flag.

For a moment, she imagined a country where nobody had to apologize for being different.

Then the anthem ended.

The students returned to their classrooms.

The day continued.

Mathematics.

English.

Science.

History.

Lunch.

Another period.

Another bell.

Everything appeared ordinary.

But inside Aratrika's schoolbag, a small notebook carried words that were slowly becoming something more than words.

They were becoming a voice.

And Aratrika was beginning to discover that a voice, once found, was difficult to silence.

Chapter 3

Words Beneath the Mattress

Aratrika had discovered that every house had places where people kept things they did not want others to find.

Some people used locked drawers.

Some used cupboards.

Some hid letters inside old books.

Aratrika used the space beneath her mattress.

It was not a very good hiding place.

She knew that.

But nobody in her house had ever thought to look there.

At night, after everyone had gone to sleep, she would quietly pull the notebook from beneath her pillow, write for a few minutes, and then slide it beneath the mattress.

The notebook had begun to grow heavier.

Not because of its weight.

Because of its words.

There were pages about school.

Pages about books.

Pages about people she admired.

Pages about things she disliked.

And pages about things she did not yet understand.

One page contained only a single question:

Why are some people allowed to dream while others are told what their dreams should be?

She had written it three times.

Each time, she had underlined it.

She still had no answer.

One Saturday afternoon, Aratrika returned home earlier than usual.

The house was unusually quiet.

Her mother was in the kitchen.

Her father had gone out.

Her younger cousin, who was visiting for the weekend, was watching television in the living room.

Aratrika went to her room.

She closed the door.

Then she opened her schoolbag.

The notebook was missing.

Her heart stopped.

She searched the bag again.

Textbooks.

Exercise books.

Pencil case.

Water bottle.

Nothing.

She looked beneath the desk.

Nothing.

Inside the cupboard.

Nothing.

Her hands began to shake.

She remembered leaving the notebook on her bed that morning.

Had someone found it?

She rushed toward the mattress.

She lifted it.

The notebook was there.

A wave of relief passed through her.

Then she noticed something.

The notebook was not positioned exactly as she had left it.

Someone had moved it.

She opened the first page.

Everything looked normal.

She turned another.

Then another.

Nothing appeared missing.

Perhaps nobody had read it.

Perhaps she had simply forgotten where she had placed it.

She closed the notebook.

But the relief did not return completely.

For the first time, Aratrika understood that privacy was not something she could assume.

It was something she had to protect.

That night, she wrote about it.

Today I was afraid someone had read my words.

She paused.

Then continued.

Why was I afraid?

She thought for a long time.

The answer came slowly.

Because words become dangerous when people refuse to understand them.

She looked at the sentence.

Then added:

Perhaps silence is not always weakness.

Sometimes silence is a room where words wait until they are strong enough to leave.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the neighbourhood had become quiet.

A dog barked somewhere in the distance.

A train passed far away.

Aratrika switched off the light.

She lay beneath the blanket and stared at the ceiling.

Tomorrow would be another day.

Another school day.

Another set of lessons.

Another set of expectations.

She wondered how long she could keep her two lives separate.

The girl everyone knew.

And the girl who lived inside the notebook.

Monday arrived quickly.

At school, Aratrika had an English class.

The teacher asked the students to write a short paragraph about
“The Person I Want to Become.”

The classroom immediately filled with whispers.

Some students wrote about becoming doctors.

Others wanted to become engineers, teachers, scientists, officers or entrepreneurs.

Aratrika stared at the blank page.

She knew exactly what she wanted to write.

But she hesitated.

The teacher walked between the desks.

“Come on, everyone. Don't overthink it.”

Aratrika lowered her head.

She began writing.

I want to become a person whose existence makes someone else believe that they can become more than what the world expects of them.

She stopped.

That was all.

She did not write a profession.

She did not write a salary.

She did not write about fame.

She wrote about becoming a person.

When the teacher collected the notebooks, Aratrika almost regretted what she had written.

But the teacher stopped beside her desk.

She read the paragraph.

Then looked at Aratrika.

“Interesting.”

Aratrika waited.

“Why didn't you mention a career?”

Aratrika thought about the question.

“Because a career tells people what I do,” she said quietly. “I think character tells people who I am.”

The teacher smiled.

“Keep writing.”

Two words.

Nothing more.

But Aratrika carried them with her for the rest of the day.

That evening, she opened her notebook again.

At the top of a fresh page, she wrote:

KEEP WRITING.

She stared at the words.

Then beneath them, she wrote:

Maybe that is all I need to do.

The page remained open beside her.

For once, she did not hide it immediately.

She let the words sit beneath the evening light.

Perhaps she was beginning to understand something.

A person could hide a notebook.

A person could hide a thought.

A person could hide a dream.

But once a word had been written honestly, it became very difficult to erase what had created it.

Aratrika closed the notebook.

Then she placed it beneath the mattress.

The words waited there.

Quietly.

Patiently.

Growing.

Chapter 4

The Girl at the Window

There was a window in Aratrika's room that faced the road.

It was not a particularly beautiful view.

There were houses packed closely together, electrical wires crossing the sky, a tea stall at the corner and a narrow road where bicycles, buses and pedestrians competed for space.

But Aratrika loved the window.

From there, she could watch the world without being required to participate in it.

Every morning, she saw the same things.

The milkman arriving.

Children walking to school.

Shopkeepers lifting their shutters.

Workers waiting for buses.

Women carrying shopping bags.

Old men sitting outside the tea stall and discussing the day's news.

The neighbourhood was ordinary.

But Aratrika had learned that ordinary places were full of extraordinary stories.

She only had to notice them.

One afternoon, she sat beside the window with her mathematics textbook open.

The textbook had been open for almost twenty minutes.

She had not read a single line.

Her attention was outside.

An old woman was walking slowly along the road.

She stopped beside a small flower seller.

The seller handed her a bunch of flowers.

The woman counted some coins and gave them to him.

Then she walked away.

Aratrika wondered where she was going.

Perhaps to a temple.

Perhaps to someone's house.

Perhaps to visit a person she loved.

She would never know.

That thought fascinated her.

Every person she saw had a story she would never hear.

She opened her notebook.

Every window is a library.

She paused.

Then continued.

Every person outside carries a book that nobody else can completely read.

She smiled.

The sentence felt right.

She wrote another.

Perhaps writing is simply the attempt to read those invisible books.

“Aratrika.”

She looked up.

Her mother stood at the door.

“Why are you sitting there again?”

“I’m studying.”

Her mother looked at the textbook.

“You’ve been on the same page for half an hour.”

Aratrika closed the notebook.

“I was thinking.”

“Thinking won’t finish your syllabus.”

Aratrika said nothing.

Her mother sighed.

“Your exams are important.”

“I know.”

“You have to concentrate.”

“I will.”

Her mother left.

Aratrika looked at the closed textbook.

She knew her mother was not entirely wrong.

Examinations mattered.

She wanted to do well.

Very well.

But sometimes she wished the adults around her understood that studying and thinking were not enemies.

She opened the mathematics book again.

This time, she began solving the problem.

The following week, something unexpected happened at school.

The English teacher announced that the school would hold a writing competition.

The topic was:

“The India I Want to See.”

The classroom immediately became noisy.

Some students were excited.

Others complained.

Aratrika remained silent.

The teacher wrote the topic on the board.

“Anyone who wants to participate can submit an entry by Friday.”

A hand went up.

“Ma'am, is there a word limit?”

“About one thousand words.”

Another student asked, “Can we write in Bengali?”

“Yes.”

Aratrika looked at the board.

For several seconds, she could not move.

Bengali.

Her mother tongue.

The language in which she thought when she was alone.

The language of the poems she loved.

The language of the notebook beneath her mattress.

She raised her hand.

“Yes, Aratrika?”

“I'll participate.”

The teacher nodded.

“Good.”

That simple decision frightened her.

Until then, her writing had belonged only to her.

Now someone else would read it.

Perhaps judge it.

Perhaps criticize it.

Perhaps laugh at it.

But she had already raised her hand.

There was no taking it back.

That evening, she sat beside the window.

The sun was setting.

The sky had turned orange.

The road below was becoming quieter.

She opened a fresh notebook.

At the top of the first page, she wrote:

The India I Want to See

Then she stopped.

She did not want to write about monuments.

She did not want to list famous achievements.

She did not want to repeat sentences she had read in textbooks.

She wanted to write about people.

About the girl who was told that her dreams were too large.

About the boy who was told that failure made him worthless.

About families that measured children only by marks.

About children who were taught to fear questions.

About people who were judged before they were understood.

She began writing.

The words came slowly at first.

Then faster.

She wrote until the evening became night.

She wrote until her fingers hurt.

She wrote until the page was filled.

Then she turned it over.

And continued.

Near midnight, she finally stopped.

She read what she had written.

It was not perfect.

Some sentences were awkward.

Some ideas needed improvement.

But it was hers.

She had not copied it from a book.

She had not written what she thought someone wanted to hear.

She had written what she believed.

Aratrika placed the pages carefully inside a folder.

Then she looked through the window.

The street was almost empty.

A single streetlight illuminated the road.

She wondered how many people were awake behind the hundreds of windows around her.

How many were studying.

How many were dreaming.

How many were afraid.

How many had something to say but nobody willing to listen.

She whispered to herself:

“Maybe someday.”

She did not know what the words meant.

Maybe someday she would publish a book.

Maybe someday she would speak before a crowd.

Maybe someday she would change something.

Or maybe someday she would simply understand herself better.

For now, writing was enough.

She closed the window.

Then placed the folder beside her schoolbooks.

For the first time, Aratrika was not hiding her words beneath the mattress.

She was preparing to let them leave the room.

And she did not yet know that once words leave their writer, they begin a journey of their own.

Chapter 5

What They Called Her

By the following Monday, the writing competition had become the most discussed event in Aratrika's class.

Not because everyone cared about writing.

Mostly because everyone wanted to know who would win.

“I heard the winner gets a certificate.”

“And a book set.”

“No, I think there is a trophy.”

“Who cares? I'll win anyway.”

The classroom filled with predictions.

Aratrika sat quietly at her desk.

Her essay was inside her schoolbag.

She had read it three times that morning.

Each time, she found something she wanted to change.

She had finally stopped herself.

If she kept editing, she would never submit it.

A girl dropped into the seat beside her.

“Are you participating?”

Aratrika looked up.

It was Krittika.

They had been classmates for years, though they were not particularly close.

Krittika was confident, outspoken and rarely seemed afraid of saying what she thought.

“Yes,” Aratrika replied.

“What did you write about?”

“The topic.”

Krittika laughed.

“You know what I meant.”

Aratrika smiled.

“I’m keeping it secret.”

“Fine. Then I’ll keep mine secret too.”

“What did you write?”

“That's a secret.”

They both laughed.

It was a small conversation.

Neither of them knew that years later, Krittika would remember it.

Krittika noticed things about Aratrika that many others didn't.

She noticed that Aratrika rarely spoke unless she had something meaningful to say.

She noticed that Aratrika always carried a notebook.

She noticed that when teachers asked difficult questions, Aratrika often knew the answer but sometimes waited before raising her hand.

And she noticed that Aratrika wrote whenever she was alone.

One afternoon, Krittika saw her writing near the classroom window.

“What are you writing?”

Aratrika quickly closed the notebook.

“Nothing.”

“You always say that.”

“Because it's usually nothing.”

Krittika leaned against the desk.

“Then why do you look so serious when you're writing nothing?”

Aratrika laughed.

“I don't know.”

Krittika looked at the notebook.

“You should publish something someday.”

Aratrika looked surprised.

“Why?”

“Because you write all the time.”

“That doesn't mean it's good.”

“Neither does talking,” Krittika replied. “And I still talk.”

Aratrika laughed again.

For the first time, she saw Krittika differently.

Perhaps friendship did not always begin with a dramatic moment.

Perhaps sometimes it began with a joke.

At home that evening, Aratrika placed her essay on the dining table.

Mr. Saha was reading the newspaper.

Mrs. Saha was arranging dinner.

“What is that?” her father asked.

“An essay.”

“For school?”

“Yes.”

“Competition?”

“Yes.”

Mr. Saha picked up the pages.

He read the title.

The India I Want to See.

He looked at Aratrika.

“What have you written?”

“About the kind of country I want.”

He read the first paragraph.

Then another.

His expression became difficult for her to understand.

Finally, he put the pages down.

“You spend too much time thinking about things beyond your age.”

Aratrika looked at him.

“Is that bad?”

“You should concentrate on your studies first.”

“I do.”

“Then let these things come later.”

Aratrika wanted to ask when “later” would arrive.

She didn't.

Mrs. Saha quietly took the papers from the table.

She read them.

Unlike her husband, she did not immediately say anything.

After a while, she handed them back.

“Your handwriting is very neat,” she said.

Aratrika smiled.

“Thank you.”

It was not the response she had hoped for.

But it was enough.

The next morning, something happened that Aratrika would remember for years.

The teacher returned the essays.

Some students were disappointed.

Some were excited.

A few immediately began comparing their marks.

Aratrika waited.

Her paper finally reached her desk.

At the top was a red mark.

Excellent.

Underneath, the teacher had written:

Your ideas are mature. Continue writing.

Aratrika stared at the words.

Continue writing.

Again.

Those three words seemed to follow her everywhere.

She folded the paper carefully and placed it inside her notebook.

Krittika leaned across.

“What did you get?”

Aratrika showed her.

Krittika smiled.

“I knew it.”

“You didn't even read it.”

“I didn't need to.”

“How?”

“You look different when you're proud of something.”

Aratrika looked away.

“I'm not proud.”

“You are.”

“Maybe a little.”

Krittika smiled.

“Good.”

That afternoon, Aratrika went to the library.

She liked the library because it was quiet without being lonely.

She walked between the shelves.

Books stood in rows, each carrying someone else's thoughts.

She pulled out a Bengali literature book.

As she opened it, a loose sheet of paper fell from between the pages.

She picked it up.

It contained a handwritten sentence:

Words do not disappear merely because nobody hears them.

Aratrika stared at it.

She had no idea who had written it.

She put the paper back inside the book.

Then she took out her own notebook.

She wrote the sentence down.

Below it, she added:

But sometimes they need someone to carry them.

She closed the notebook.

Outside the library window, the afternoon sun was fading.

Aratrika did not know who had written the mysterious sentence.

She did not know that many years later, she would come to understand exactly what it meant.

That night, she returned home and found her mother folding clothes.

“Ma?”

“Yes?”

“Do you think writing can change anything?”

Mrs. Saha paused.

“What do you mean?”

“If someone writes something important, can it change people's thinking?”

Her mother considered the question.

“Sometimes.”

“Do you believe that?”

“I believe words can stay with people.”

Aratrika smiled.

That answer was enough.

Later that night, she went to her room.

She opened the notebook.

The house was silent.

She wrote:

Today someone told me that words can stay with people.

Then she added:

Maybe that is why I write.

She closed the notebook.

For a moment, she looked toward the mattress where she usually hid it.

Then she hesitated.

Instead, she placed the notebook inside an old cloth bag and tucked it behind a stack of books.

It was a slightly safer hiding place.

At least, she hoped it was.

She switched off the light.

Outside, the night stretched quietly across the neighbourhood.

And somewhere in another part of the city, a boy who did not yet know how important Aratrika's writing would become was beginning to notice the girl who always carried a notebook.

His name was **Prangik**.

But Aratrika had not met him properly yet.

Their story would come later.

For now, the notebook remained hidden.

The words continued to grow.

And Aratrika continued to write.

II

The Girl Who Wrote

Chapter 6

Ink

The first thing Prangik noticed about Aratrika was not her face.

It was her handwriting.

He had seen it on the classroom notice board.

The school had displayed the results of the writing competition, and beneath the names of the selected students was a handwritten note from the English teacher.

Aratrika's name was there.

Prangik stopped in front of the board.

He read it once.

Then again.

He did not know her particularly well.

They had been in the same school for years, but school was a strange place. Hundreds of students could walk through the same corridors every day without ever really knowing one another.

Prangik knew Aratrika as the quiet girl who answered difficult questions occasionally.

The girl who carried too many books.

The girl who sometimes sat near the window.

But he had never known that she wrote.

He looked at her name again.

Then he walked away.

A few days later, Prangik happened to enter the library during lunch.

He preferred the library to the noisy playground.

As he walked between the shelves, he noticed someone sitting near the window.

Aratrika.

She was writing.

Again.

Prangik stopped for a moment.

He did not want to interrupt her.

Instead, he selected a book from the shelf and sat at a table some distance away.

For several minutes, neither spoke.

Then Aratrika dropped her pen.

It rolled across the floor.

Prangik picked it up before it reached the next table.

“Here.”

“Thank you.”

Their eyes met briefly.

“You're Aratrika, right?”

“Yes.”

“I saw your name on the writing competition list.”

“Oh.”

“You write?”

Aratrika looked at the notebook in front of her.

“Sometimes.”

Prangik smiled.

“That’s a lot of pages for sometimes.”

She laughed quietly.

“Maybe.”

He handed the pen back.

Chapter 7

The Pages Between Them

After that afternoon in the library, Prangik began noticing Aratrika more often.

Not deliberately.

At least, that was what he told himself.

He noticed her sitting near the classroom window.

He noticed her carrying the same old notebook everywhere.

He noticed that she wrote whenever there was a few minutes of silence.

During free periods.

Before assembly.

After lunch.

Sometimes even while waiting for the teacher to arrive.

But there was something else he noticed.

Aratrika never allowed anyone to read what she wrote.

One afternoon, Krittika tried to look over her shoulder.

“What are you writing now?”

“Nothing.”

“You always say that.”

“Because you’re always asking.”

Krittika laughed.

Prangik, sitting a few desks away, smiled.

He had begun to understand that the notebook was important to her.

It was not simply a notebook.

It was a place where Aratrika could say things she did not say aloud.

The next week, their English teacher announced another assignment.

“Write something about a person who changed the way you think.”

The classroom became noisy.

Some students immediately chose famous personalities.

Others chose parents, teachers or relatives.

Aratrika remained quiet.

Prangik glanced at her.

She had already opened her notebook.

He wondered who she would choose.

After class, he found her in the corridor.

“What did you write?”

She looked at him.

“Why do you want to know?”

“Because I'm curious.”

“You'll have to wait.”

“Fair enough.”

She smiled.

“Who did you choose?”

“I haven't decided.”

“You've already written three pages.”

Aratrika looked surprised.

“How did you know?”

“You write very quickly.”

She laughed.

“You notice too much.”

“Maybe.”

For a moment neither spoke.

Then the bell rang.

Students began moving through the corridor.

Aratrika closed her notebook.

“I have to go.”

“See you.”

“See you.”

She walked away.

Prangik watched her disappear into the crowd.

He realized something then.

He did not particularly want to know what was inside the notebook because he wanted to invade her privacy.

He wanted to know because he admired the person who could fill so many pages with thoughts.

That evening, Aratrika sat at her desk.

The assignment was still unfinished.

She thought about the question.

Who changed the way you think?

She considered her parents.

Her teachers.

Her classmates.

Writers whose books she had read.

Then she realized something.

Perhaps nobody had changed the way she thought.

Perhaps she had simply begun questioning things herself.

She wrote:

Sometimes the person who changes your thinking is not another person.

Sometimes it is the moment when you finally decide to think for yourself.

She stopped.

Then she continued.

And sometimes a single sentence is enough to open a door that you did not know existed.

She read the paragraph.

It reminded her of the mysterious sentence she had found in the library.

Words do not disappear merely because nobody hears them.

She wondered again who had written it.

The next day, she returned to the library.

She searched for the book.

It was still there.

She opened it.

The loose sheet of paper was gone.

Someone had taken it.

Aratrika felt strangely disappointed.

She had wanted to know whether the sentence had been written by a student or a teacher.

Perhaps she would never know.

She sat by the window.

A few minutes later, Prangik entered.

He saw her.

“Again?”

“Again.”

He sat opposite her.

“What are you writing?”

“An assignment.”

“Can I read it?”

Aratrika looked at him.

There was a pause.

“No.”

Prangik immediately nodded.

“Okay.”

No argument.

No insistence.

He opened his own book.

Aratrika looked at him for a moment.

She had expected another question.

There wasn't one.

That made her trust him slightly more.

She returned to her writing.

A few minutes passed.

Then Aratrika quietly pushed one page toward him.

“You can read this part.”

Prangik looked surprised.

“Are you sure?”

“Yes.”

He picked up the page carefully.

He read it without speaking.

When he finished, he placed it back on the table.

“This is good.”

Aratrika smiled uncertainly.

“You don't have to say that.”

“I know.”

“Then why did you?”

“Because I meant it.”

She looked down at the page.

For some reason, those words mattered.

Not because he had praised her.

Because he had read her writing and had not laughed.

He had not told her it was childish.

He had not told her to concentrate on something more useful.

He had simply read it.

And understood.

That night, Aratrika opened her notebook.

She wrote:

Today I allowed someone to read one page.

She paused.

Then added:

It felt strange.

Another pause.

Perhaps trust begins with a single page.

She closed the notebook.

She did not write Prangik's name.

Not yet.

Some things were still too new to name.

Across the city, Prangik was thinking about the page he had read.

He could not remember every sentence.

But he remembered the feeling it had left behind.

He had discovered something about Aratrika.

She was not quiet because she had nothing to say.

She was quiet because she had too much.

And perhaps that was why she wrote.

Because paper could hold everything that a voice sometimes could not.

Chapter 8

Class Ten

The calendar changed quietly.

One month disappeared.

Then another.

The classroom remained the same, but the students did not.

Class Ten had begun to feel different.

The teachers spoke more seriously.

The homework became longer.

The examinations became more important.

Even conversations during lunch had changed.

“Which stream are you taking?”

“What are you planning after Class Ten?”

“How much do you think you'll score?”

Everyone seemed to be measuring the future.

Aratrika listened.

She had never been afraid of examinations.

She was afraid of what people did with marks.

A number could become a celebration.

A number could become a comparison.

A number could become a judgement.

And sometimes, a number could make people forget the person behind it.

One morning, the mathematics teacher returned a test.

“Excellent work, Aratrika.”

She looked at the paper.

There were only a few red marks.

Krittika leaned over.

“How much?”

“Full marks.”

Krittika grinned.

“I knew it.”

Aratrika smiled.

Prangik, sitting behind them, heard the conversation.

He had done reasonably well too.

But he wasn't looking at his own paper.

He was looking at Aratrika's.

Not because of the marks.

Because she had written a tiny sentence in the corner of the page.

One mistake doesn't erase everything you know.

He wondered why she had written it.

Later, he asked.

“You wrote something on your mathematics paper.”

Aratrika looked surprised.

“You noticed?”

“Yes.”

“It's nothing.”

“You write that a lot.”

She laughed.

“Maybe I should find another word.”

“Please do.”

They both smiled.

As the months passed, Aratrika's notebook became thicker.

She had stopped hiding every page from everyone.

But there were still parts nobody was allowed to see.

Those pages contained her deepest thoughts.

Her fears.

Her questions.

Her dreams.

And sometimes her anger.

One evening, she wrote:

I don't want to spend my whole life proving that I deserve to be heard.

She stared at the sentence.

Then continued:

I want a world where people listen before asking what I have achieved.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the streetlights had come on.

At school, Krittika had begun spending more time with her.

They studied together sometimes.

They argued about books.

They disagreed about almost everything.

Krittika was more outspoken.

Aratrika was more reflective.

Krittika would say something immediately.

Aratrika would think about it first.

Yet somehow, the difference worked.

One afternoon, they sat beneath a tree during lunch.

Krittika asked, “What do you actually want to do after school?”

“I’m not sure.”

“You always say that.”

“Because I’m not sure.”

“You write like someone who knows exactly what she wants.”

Aratrika smiled.

“Writing is easier than living.”

Krittika became quiet.

“What do you mean?”

Aratrika looked at the playground.

“I can write the ending of a story. I can't do that with my life.”

Krittika thought about it.

Then she said, “Maybe that's the point.”

“What?”

“Maybe you don't get to write the ending beforehand.”

Aratrika smiled.

“I like that.”

“Write it down, then.”

Aratrika took out her notebook.

Krittika laughed.

“You actually wrote it?”

“Yes.”

Prangik saw them from the corridor.

He smiled.

He was glad Aratrika had someone she could talk to.

He had never told anyone how much he admired her writing.

Not even his closest friends.

There was something about her words that stayed with him.

He sometimes remembered lines she had shown him weeks earlier.

He had begun writing down a few of his own thoughts too.

Not because he wanted to become a writer.

Because Aratrika had made him notice things.

A sunset.

A sentence.

A silent classroom.

A person sitting alone.

He wondered whether that was what good writing did.

Perhaps good writing did not simply tell you something.

Perhaps it made you see something you had been looking at all along.

As the final examinations drew closer, the atmosphere at home changed.

Mr. Saha began reminding Aratrika about her studies every evening.

“Your board examinations are important.”

“I know, Baba.”

“Don't waste time.”

“I won't.”

Mrs. Saha quietly brought her tea while she studied.

“Don't stay awake too late.”

“I'll sleep soon.”

“You always say that.”

Aratrika smiled.

“I promise.”

Her parents worried about her future in their own way.

They did not always understand her.

But they wanted her to succeed.

Aratrika knew that.

That knowledge made everything more complicated.

Because people could love you and still fail to understand you.

She was beginning to learn that both things could be true.

One night, she opened the notebook.

The pages were nearly full.

She turned to the final blank page.

For a long time, she simply looked at it.

Then she wrote:

Class Ten is not the end.

She stopped.

Then added:

Perhaps it is only the first page people will remember.

She closed the notebook.

She did not know how important those words would become.

She did not know that her Class Ten result would eventually be remembered far beyond her classroom.

She did not know that a list would soon be prepared at school.

A list of names.

A list that would contain many students.

But not hers.

And she certainly did not know that the absence of her name would become one of the moments that changed her life.

For now, she was simply a Class Ten student.

Studying.

Writing.

Dreaming.

And waiting for the future to turn the page.

Chapter 9

The Notebook

The notebook had become old.

The corners were bent.

Several pages had begun to loosen from the binding.

The cover, once clean, had acquired faint marks from years of being carried in Aratrika's schoolbag.

Krittika had once suggested that she buy a new one.

“You've almost finished this.”

“I know.”

“So buy another.”

“I can't.”

“Why?”

Aratrika looked at the notebook.

“Because this one remembers everything.”

Krittika laughed.

“It’s a notebook, Aratrika.”

“No.”

She held it carefully.

“It remembers.”

Krittika smiled.

“You’re strange.”

“Probably.”

But Aratrika knew what she meant.

Every page belonged to a particular moment.

The first sentence she had written near the window.

The writing competition.

The mysterious sentence in the library.

The first page she had allowed Prangik to read.

The questions she had never asked aloud.

The fears she had never admitted.

Everything was there.

The notebook was becoming a record of a girl who was changing.

One afternoon, Prangik asked her about it.

“Do you still write in that?”

“Yes.”

“How much?”

“Almost every day.”

“Can I read another page?”

Aratrika looked at him.

“Maybe.”

“That's progress.”

She smiled.

“Don't get used to it.”

He laughed.

She opened the notebook.

But before she could choose a page, someone called her name.

“Aratrika!”

It was Krittika.

She came running toward them.

“Come quickly.”

“What happened?”

“The Student Cabinet list is being prepared.”

Aratrika closed the notebook.

“So?”

“They’re asking students to submit their names.”

Aratrika stood.

“Okay.”

She put the notebook inside her bag.

Then she followed Kritika toward the main office.

The Student Cabinet was one of the most important things in school.

Prefects.

House representatives.

Student leaders.

The names were displayed publicly.

Students admired those positions.

Teachers trusted them.

Parents talked about them.

Aratrika had never been obsessed with becoming a leader.

But she had always wanted to contribute.

When the teacher asked for names, Krittika submitted hers.

Aratrika hesitated.

“You should submit yours too,” Krittika said.

“I don’t know.”

“You’re capable.”

“That’s different.”

“How?”

Aratrika shrugged.

“Being capable doesn’t mean people will choose you.”

Krittika looked at her.

“Then give them a chance to choose.”

Aratrika smiled.

She wrote her name.

Aratrika Saha.

Then she handed the form to the teacher.

It was a small act.

She did not think about it again.

Weeks passed.

Examinations came closer.

The school corridors became quieter.

Students carried revision notes everywhere.

Teachers spoke about preparation.

Parents spoke about results.

The word **future** seemed to appear in every conversation.

Aratrika studied harder.

At night, she continued writing.

But her entries became shorter.

Sometimes only a sentence.

I am tired.

I wonder whether success will feel different from what I imagine.

What happens when everyone expects you to succeed?

And one night:

I don't want to become a number.

She stared at that sentence.

Then added:

But perhaps numbers are the language the world understands.

She closed the notebook.

The Student Cabinet list was supposed to be announced on Friday.

Friday arrived.

The corridor outside the office was crowded.

Students gathered around the notice board.

Krittika pushed through the crowd.

“Move!”

Aratrika followed.

The paper had been pinned to the board.

Names were arranged under different positions.

Krittika scanned the list.

Then stopped.

Aratrika looked at her.

“What?”

Krittika didn't answer immediately.

“Your name...”

Aratrika stepped closer.

She read the list.

Once.

Twice.

Then again.

Her name wasn't there.

She checked every section.

Prefects.

Representatives.

House positions.

Committees.

Nothing.

Krittika looked uncomfortable.

“Maybe there's another list.”

“Maybe.”

Aratrika smiled.

But it was not her usual smile.

She stepped away from the crowd.

The hallway suddenly seemed very loud.

Students were celebrating around her.

Someone had been selected.

Someone else had been chosen for a position.

Teachers were congratulating students.

Aratrika heard everything.

Yet somehow, none of it seemed real.

She walked toward the library.

She sat beside the same window where she had once discovered the mysterious sentence.

She took out her notebook.

For several minutes, she did not write.

Then she opened to a blank page.

Her hand trembled slightly.

She wrote:

Today my name was missing.

She stopped.

Then:

It is strange how much pain can fit inside an empty space.

She stared at the sentence.

A tear fell onto the page.

She wiped it away quickly.

Then she continued.

Maybe I was wrong to think that being capable was enough.

She closed the notebook.

But before putting it away, she wrote one final sentence:

If they don't give me a place on their list, I will build a place where my words can stand.

She underlined it.

Once.

Twice.

Then she closed the notebook.

Outside the library, the school bell rang.

Aratrika remained by the window.

She did not know it yet, but the empty space beside her missing name would become the beginning of something much larger.

And years later, when people looked at the dusty diary preserved in a museum, they would find that sentence among its earliest surviving pages.

If they don't give me a place on their list, I will build a place where my words can stand.

Chapter 10

The Empty Space

For the next few days, Aratrika avoided the notice board.

She did not want to look at the list again.

She knew her name wasn't there.

Seeing it once had been enough.

But school continued as though nothing had happened.

The morning bell rang.

Teachers entered classrooms.

Students laughed in the corridors.

Assignments were submitted.

Tests were conducted.

Life did not pause simply because one person had been disappointed.

Aratrika found that strangely comforting.

The world had not ended.

Only one expectation had.

Krittika noticed that Aratrika had become quieter.

One afternoon, she followed her into the library.

“You've been avoiding me.”

“I haven't.”

“You have.”

Aratrika placed her book on the table.

“I just have a lot of studying.”

Krittika sat opposite her.

“It's about the list, isn't it?”

Aratrika didn't answer.

“You deserved a place.”

III

Beyond the List

Chapter 11

The Girl Who Wasn't Chosen

“You did.”

“How do you know?”

“Because I’ve seen what you do.”

Krittika said it quietly.

There was no dramatic certainty in her voice. No attempt to make Aratrika feel better with a speech.

She simply meant it.

Aratrika looked down at the notebook resting on her lap.

The library was almost empty that afternoon. Outside, students were leaving through the corridor, their voices rising and fading. Somewhere near the staircase, someone laughed loudly.

The ordinary world had continued.

That was what Aratrika found strange.

Her name had been missing from the list.

And yet the bell had rung.

Classes had ended.

Teachers had gone home.

Students had discussed homework.

The world had not stopped to notice the empty space.

“I thought I would be angry,” Aratrika said.

Krittika pulled out the chair opposite her.

“And?”

“I don’t know.”

She opened the notebook.

The page still carried the sentence she had written the previous day.

Today my name was missing.

Below it, she had written nothing.

For the first time, the blankness of the page did not frighten her.

It challenged her.

Krittika leaned forward.

“Are you going to stop writing?”

Aratrika looked up immediately.

“No.”

“Good.”

“Why?”

“Because then whoever didn’t choose you gets to decide what you become.”

Aratrika remained silent.

The sentence stayed with her.

She had spent the last two days thinking about the people whose names were on the list.

She had wondered what they had that she didn’t.

Confidence?

Popularity?

Leadership?

Perhaps they deserved their places.

Perhaps she had simply misunderstood what the school was looking for.

But Krittika had given her another question.

What if being left off the list was not the end of her story?

What if it was only the first time she had been told no?

Aratrika closed the notebook.

“I’ll try again.”

Krittika smiled.

“I knew you would.”

The next morning, Aratrika reached school earlier than usual.

The corridors were still quiet.

Sunlight entered through the tall windows and fell across the classroom floor in long rectangles.

She stood before the notice board.

The Student Cabinet list was still there.

Names.

Names.

Names.

And no Aratrika.

She looked at it for a few seconds.

Then she turned away.

For the first time, she did not feel the need to search for her name.

She walked to her classroom and placed her bag on the desk.

On the blackboard someone had written:

MONDAY — NEW WEEK. NEW BEGINNING.

Aratrika almost smiled.

New beginnings were easy to write about.

Living them was harder.

During the first period, their English teacher returned the previous week's assignments.

One by one, papers were placed on desks.

When the teacher reached Aratrika, she paused.

“Your writing has changed.”

Aratrika looked up.

“Changed?”

“It has become more direct.”

The teacher placed the paper on her desk.

“Earlier, you described things beautifully. Now you’re beginning to question them.”

Aratrika looked at the red remarks on the page.

At the bottom was a short sentence:

Your voice is becoming clearer.

She read it twice.

Then she folded the paper carefully and placed it inside her notebook.

It was not a position.

It was not a badge.

It was not her name on a list.

But it was something.

Someone had noticed.

Over the next few weeks, Aratrika began doing small things.

Nothing that attracted applause.

Nothing that appeared on a notice board.

She volunteered to read announcements when teachers needed someone.

She helped classmates understand difficult passages in English.

When a group discussion was held, she spoke.

When someone else was speaking, she listened.

She started participating in debates.

At first, her voice trembled.

Then it became steadier.

She discovered something unexpected.

Writing allowed her to speak when nobody was listening.

Speaking allowed her to make people listen while she was still in the room.

She began to understand that the two were not separate.

They were different forms of the same thing.

A voice.

One afternoon, Krittika found her sitting on the steps behind the school auditorium.

“What are you writing?”

Aratrika immediately closed the notebook.

“You always ask that.”

“And you always hide it.”

“Because it's private.”

Krittika laughed.

“Fair enough.”

She sat beside her.

For a while they watched students crossing the field.

“Do you still think about the cabinet?” Krittika asked.

Aratrika considered the question.

“Sometimes.”

“Does it still hurt?”

“Yes.”

The answer came without hesitation.

Krittika nodded.

“That doesn’t mean you’re weak.”

“I know.”

Aratrika looked at the notebook.

“It just means it mattered.”

Krittika smiled faintly.

“Then maybe you should write about it.”

“I already did.”

“Of course you did.”

They laughed.

That evening, Aratrika returned home and found her mother arranging clothes in the bedroom.

“How was school?”

“Fine.”

“Any tests?”

“No.”

Mrs. Saha looked at her.

“You seem different lately.”

Aratrika stopped.

“Different how?”

“More serious.”

Aratrika smiled.

“Maybe I’m growing up.”

Her mother sighed.

“Just don’t forget your studies.”

“I won’t.”

That answer was easy to give.

Aratrika knew her marks mattered to her parents.

They mattered to her too.

She had never disliked studying.

What she disliked was the idea that marks were supposed to be the entire definition of a person.

She wanted to prove that excellence and imagination could exist together.

That achievement did not have to silence thought.

Later that night, she opened her notebook.

For several minutes, she stared at the blank page.

Then she began writing.

They said no.

She stopped.

Crossed it out.

Started again.

They did not choose me.

She stopped again.

Then she wrote:

**Perhaps the most important thing about being rejected is
what you do after nobody chooses you.**

The sentence felt different from her earlier writing.

Less wounded.

More certain.

She continued.

A list can decide where you stand in a room. It cannot decide how far you will walk after leaving that room.

She read the sentence again.

Then she added:

I was not chosen.

A pause.

But I am still here.

She put down her pen.

For the first time since the notice board incident, she did not feel like she had lost something.

She felt as though she had discovered something.

Not a position.

Not recognition.

Not approval.

A direction.

The following week, the school announced an inter-class speaking activity.

Students were invited to speak about an issue they believed mattered to young people.

Krittika immediately turned toward Aratrika.

“You’re doing it.”

Aratrika shook her head.

“No.”

“You are.”

“I write. I don’t give speeches.”

“You’ve been giving speeches to your notebook for years.”

“That doesn’t count.”

“It counts more than you think.”

Aratrika laughed.

But that evening, she filled out the form.

Under **Topic**, she wrote:

What Makes a Person Worth Listening To?

She stared at the words.

Then, underneath them, she added another sentence.

Maybe being chosen is not the same as being heard.

She signed her name.

This time, there was no cabinet list.

No selection board.

No promise that anyone would choose her.

There was only a stage waiting somewhere in the school auditorium.

And Aratrika had decided to step toward it.

The girl who had not been chosen had begun choosing herself.

Chapter 12

A Voice Without a Stage

The auditorium was fuller than Aratrika had expected.

Rows of students filled the seats.

Teachers stood along the sides.

A microphone waited at the centre of the stage.

Aratrika stood behind the curtain, holding a few sheets of paper.

Her hands were cold.

She had spoken in classrooms before.

She had participated in discussions.

She had read poems aloud.

But this was different.

Here, everyone would be looking at her.

Krittika stood beside her.

“You’re nervous.”

“No.”

“You’re holding your paper upside down.”

Aratrika looked down.

It was.

Krittika laughed.

“I’m fine,” Aratrika said.

“I know.”

Krittika straightened the papers for her.

“Just remember what you told me.”

“What?”

“You don’t need everyone to agree with you. You only need to say what you actually believe.”

Aratrika nodded.

The teacher supervising the programme called her name.

“Aratrika Saha.”

For a second, she could not move.

Then she stepped onto the stage.

The applause was polite.

She reached the microphone.

The auditorium became quiet.

She looked at the rows of students.

For one brief moment, she remembered the Student Cabinet list.

Her missing name.

The empty space.

Then she remembered what she had written.

A list can decide where you stand in a room. It cannot decide how far you will walk after leaving that room.

She took a breath.

“Good morning.”

Her voice sounded smaller than she expected.

She continued.

“My topic is simple: What makes a person worth listening to?”

The auditorium remained silent.

“Is it a position? A title? A certificate? Marks? Popularity?”

She paused.

“Or is it the courage to say something that matters?”

A few students looked up.

Aratrika continued.

“We often teach young people to speak only after they have achieved something. We tell them that their opinions will matter later, when they become older, more successful or more qualified.”

She looked toward the teachers.

“But perhaps we forget that every person begins somewhere.”

Her voice became steadier.

“A student can have an idea before becoming a leader. A child can ask an important question before becoming a scientist. A person can write something meaningful before becoming an author.”

She glanced briefly toward Krittika.

Krittika was smiling.

Aratrika continued.

“Sometimes we decide who deserves to be heard before we have even listened to them.”

The auditorium was completely silent now.

She could hear her own breathing.

“So I don't think a person becomes worth listening to because someone gives them a position.”

She paused.

“I think a person becomes worth listening to when they have something honest to say.”

For the first time, she forgot that she was nervous.

The words no longer felt like a speech.

They felt like the notebook.

The same thoughts that had once existed only on paper were now standing in front of hundreds of people.

She finished quietly.

“And perhaps the most important thing we can give another person is not an answer.”

She looked across the auditorium.

“It is the willingness to listen.”

She stepped away from the microphone.

For a second, there was silence.

Then the applause began.

It grew slowly.

Some students stood.

Then more.

Aratrika looked surprised.

She had not expected that.

She smiled.

Not because she had received applause.

Because, for the first time, the words that had lived inside her notebook had reached someone else.

After she returned backstage, Kritika hugged her briefly.

“You did it.”

Aratrika laughed.

“I nearly forgot half of it.”

“Nobody noticed.”

“You're lying.”

“Maybe.”

They laughed again.

A teacher approached them.

“Aratrika.”

She turned.

“Yes, ma'am?”

“That was very thoughtful.”

“Thank you.”

“You should participate in more speaking events.”

Aratrika nodded.

“I will.”

The teacher walked away.

Krittika looked at her.

“See?”

“See what?”

“You have a voice.”

Aratrika looked back toward the stage.

“I think I always had one.”

Krittika smiled.

“You just needed to use it.”

Later that afternoon, Aratrika returned to the library.

She sat beside the familiar window.

The same window where she had written about the world outside.

She opened her notebook.

For several minutes, she simply looked at the pages.

Then she wrote:

Today, my words left the notebook.

She paused.

Then added:

They stood beneath bright lights.

Another line followed.

And people listened.

She smiled.

Then she wrote:

Perhaps this is what writing was preparing me for.

The door opened.

Prangik entered.

He saw her and walked over.

“I heard your speech.”

Aratrika looked surprised.

“You were there?”

“Yes.”

“What did you think?”

Prangik pulled out a chair.

“I thought you sounded like the person who writes those pages.”

Aratrika smiled.

“What does that mean?”

“You didn't sound like you were trying to impress anyone.”

She looked down.

“I was terrified.”

“I couldn't tell.”

“That makes two of us.”

They laughed.

Prangik looked at the notebook.

“Did you write about it?”

“Of course.”

“Can I read it?”

Aratrika hesitated.

Then she turned the notebook toward him.

He read the page.

When he finished, he looked at her.

“You should keep this.”

“Keep what?”

“This notebook.”

“I was planning to.”

“No. I mean keep it safe.”

Aratrika smiled.

“Why?”

“Because someday you might want to remember who you were before everyone started knowing your name.”

She looked at him for a moment.

The sentence stayed with her.

She closed the notebook carefully.

“I’ll remember.”

Neither of them knew how important that promise would become.

That evening, Aratrika returned home.

Mr. Saha was sitting in the living room.

“How was school?”

“There was a speaking programme.”

“You participated?”

“Yes.”

“How did it go?”

“Fine.”

He nodded.

“Good. Now concentrate on your examinations.”

Aratrika smiled.

“I will.”

She went to her room.

She placed the notebook inside her old cloth bag.

Then she opened her textbooks.

The examinations were approaching.

There was still much to study.

The world had not changed because she had given one speech.

Her family had not changed.

The Student Cabinet list had not changed.

Her circumstances had not changed.

But something inside her had.

She had discovered that her voice could travel farther than the four walls of her room.

And once a person discovers that their words can reach others, silence never feels quite the same again.

Aratrika looked at the clock.

Then at her books.

She picked up her pen.

Tomorrow, she would study.

Tonight, she would write.

And somewhere between the two, she was becoming the person she had once only imagined.

Chapter 13

Ninety-Nine

The examination hall was quieter than any classroom Aratrika had ever known.

There were no conversations.

No laughter.

No notebooks filled with unfinished sentences.

Only desks, answer sheets, clocks and the sound of pens moving across paper.

The Class X examinations had begun.

For months, everyone had talked about this moment.

Teachers had reminded them.

Parents had reminded them.

Students had reminded one another.

Now there was nothing left to discuss.

Only the questions.

Aratrika turned the first page of her question paper.

She took a deep breath.

Then she began.

The first few days passed almost mechanically.

Wake up.

Study.

Travel to school.

Write.

Return home.

Rest.

Study again.

Sleep.

Repeat.

Her notebook remained beside her textbooks.

Sometimes she wrote for only five minutes.

Sometimes she did not write at all.

There were too many thoughts competing for space.

What if she made a mistake?

What if she forgot something?

What if her marks were not enough?

She had never considered herself afraid of failure.

But she had begun to understand that examination results carried expectations far beyond the classroom.

Her parents wanted her to succeed.

Her teachers expected her to do well.

Krittika believed in her.

Prangik believed in her writing.

And Aratrika wanted to prove something to herself.

Not that she was better than anyone else.

Only that she was capable of becoming what she wanted to become.

The final examination arrived.

When the invigilator announced that there were ten minutes remaining, Aratrika checked her answers carefully.

She found one mistake.

She corrected it.

Then she checked again.

The bell rang.

“Stop writing.”

Pens were placed on desks.

Answer sheets were collected.

It was over.

Aratrika walked out of the examination hall.

Krittika was waiting outside.

“Finally.”

Aratrika smiled.

“Finally.”

“How did it go?”

“I don’t know.”

“You always say that.”

“Because I never know.”

Krittika laughed.

“Come on.”

They walked through the school gate together.

For the first time in months, there was no examination waiting for them the next morning.

It felt strange.

The future had suddenly become empty.

The weeks after the examinations were different.

Students returned to school for various activities.

Some began planning vacations.

Others discussed colleges and streams.

Everyone eventually reached the same question.

“What do you think you'll score?”

Aratrika never knew what to answer.

She had calculated some possibilities.

Then stopped calculating.

There was no point.

The answers had already been submitted.

The marks were now somewhere beyond her control.

One evening, she sat beside her bedroom window.

Her notebook was open.

She wrote:

The strange thing about examinations is that you spend months preparing for a few hours, and then spend weeks wondering about numbers that already exist somewhere.

She paused.

Then added:

Perhaps results are simply the world's way of turning months of effort into a single page.

She closed the notebook.

She did not know how accurate that sentence would become.

The result day arrived on a bright morning.

Aratrika woke earlier than usual.

She had barely slept.

Mrs. Saha came into her room.

“Are you awake?”

“Yes.”

“Don't worry too much.”

Aratrika smiled.

“I'm trying.”

Mr. Saha was already in the living room.

He had the computer ready.

The result website was crowded with students.

Everyone seemed to be waiting.

Aratrika sat down.

Her hands were cold.

“Enter the details,” her father said.

She did.

For a moment, the screen seemed frozen.

Then the result appeared.

Aratrika stared.

She read the number once.

Then again.

Then a third time.

99%.

She did not speak.

Her mother looked at the screen.

“Aratrika...”

Her father leaned closer.

“Ninety-nine?”

She nodded.

Mrs. Saha smiled.

Her father looked at her for several seconds.

Then he placed a hand on her shoulder.

“I’m proud of you.”

Those words meant more than the number.

Aratrika smiled.

For a moment, all the pressure disappeared.

The late nights.

The examinations.

The uncertainty.

The fear.

All of it seemed to have become one number.

99.

But Aratrika knew something that the number could not show.

The number did not contain the hours she had spent helping classmates.

It did not contain the pages she had written.

It did not contain the speech in the auditorium.

It did not contain the disappointment of seeing her name missing from the Student Cabinet list.

It did not contain Krittika's encouragement.

It did not contain Prangik reading her words.

A result could measure marks.

It could not measure a life.

At school, the news spread quickly.

“Aratrika got 99!”

Students congratulated her.

Teachers smiled.

Krittika ran toward her.

“Ninety-nine!”

Aratrika laughed.

“I know.”

“You actually did it.”

“We did our exams.”

“No. You did it.”

Krittika hugged her briefly.

“You deserve this.”

Aratrika smiled.

Across the corridor, Prangik watched.

When he finally reached her, he simply said:

“Congratulations.”

“Thank you.”

“Does it feel different?”

Aratrika looked at the result sheet.

“Not really.”

“Why?”

“I still feel like me.”

Prangik smiled.

“Good.”

She looked at him.

“What?”

“Nothing.”

“Tell me.”

He shook his head.

“Just don't let the number change your writing.”

Aratrika smiled.

“It won't.”

That night, the house was unusually cheerful.

Mrs. Saha prepared Aratrika's favourite meal.

Mr. Saha called relatives.

Messages arrived from teachers and classmates.

For one evening, the number 99 seemed to fill every room.

But after everyone had gone to sleep, Aratrika sat alone beside the window.

She opened her notebook.

The page was blank.

She wrote:

99%.

Then she stared at it.

She could have written something triumphant.

Instead, she wrote:

Today everyone saw a number.

She paused.

I saw a beginning.

Then another sentence:

If marks can open doors, I want to use the door to reach places where marks cannot.

She closed the notebook.

She looked outside.

The neighbourhood was quiet.

Tomorrow, people would start asking what she planned to do next.

Which stream?

Which career?

Which college?

Which future?

For the first time, Aratrika did not feel frightened by the questions.

She did not have all the answers.

But she knew one thing.

She would continue writing.

And somewhere inside that decision was the beginning of the life she had been waiting for.

The girl who had once been missing from a school list had now become a name everyone remembered.

But Aratrika knew that being remembered was not enough.

She wanted her words to matter.

And that was a much bigger journey.

Chapter 14

Beyond the Lane

The days after the result were filled with congratulations.

Aratrika's 99% became a number people repeated with pride.

Teachers mentioned it.

Neighbours mentioned it.

Relatives called.

Even students who had barely spoken to her before stopped her in the corridor.

“Congratulations!”

“Which stream are you taking?”

“What are you planning now?”

The questions came one after another.

Aratrika answered politely.

But whenever someone asked what she wanted to become, she paused.

She had once thought that not knowing the answer meant she was uncertain.

Now she understood something else.

Perhaps she simply had too many things she wanted to understand before choosing one.

She liked science.

She loved literature.

She enjoyed debating.

She wanted to write.

And increasingly, she wanted to understand why some people were given opportunities while others were not.

The 99% had opened doors.

But she was beginning to look beyond them.

One afternoon, Kritika found her sitting in the library.

“You’ve been here for an hour.”

“I know.”

“Studying?”

“Not exactly.”

Krittika looked at the open book.

“Then what?”

Aratrika pointed toward an article she had been reading.

“It was about a girl who had to leave school.”

“Why?”

“Her family couldn’t afford it.”

Krittika sat down.

“That happens.”

“I know.”

Aratrika closed the book.

“But knowing something happens and actually thinking about it are different.”

Krittika watched her carefully.

“What are you thinking?”

“I don’t know yet.”

“That usually means you’re about to write something.”

Aratrika smiled.

“Probably.”

That evening, she began a new notebook.

The old one was becoming too precious to carry everywhere.

This new notebook had a plain cover.

On the first page, she wrote:

Things That Should Not Be Normal.

Underneath, she began making a list.

A child being forced to leave school.

A person being judged before being heard.

A family deciding someone's future without asking them.

A girl being told that her dreams are too large.

She stopped.

The list could have continued forever.

Instead, she wrote:

Maybe change begins when ordinary people stop accepting extraordinary injustice as ordinary.

She read the sentence.

Then closed the notebook.

The thought remained.

Over the following weeks, Aratrika began paying closer attention to the people around her.

She noticed the student who rarely spoke because he was afraid of making mistakes.

The girl who had stopped participating because classmates laughed at her accent.

The younger student who could not afford some of the books required for class.

The workers who arrived before the school gates opened and left after most students had gone home.

She began talking to them.

Not as a leader.

Not as someone who had all the answers.

Simply as another person.

She discovered that people often had stories nobody had asked them to tell.

And she listened.

At school, Krittika sometimes accompanied her.

“You’re collecting stories now,” Krittika said one afternoon.

“Maybe.”

“What are you going to do with them?”

“Write.”

Krittika smiled.

“Of course.”

But something had changed between them.

Krittika was proud of Aratrika.

At the same time, she occasionally felt something she could not quite explain.

Aratrika seemed to be moving toward something larger.

Teachers noticed her.

Students listened to her.

Her writing was becoming stronger.

Krittika sometimes wondered whether she would eventually be left behind.

She never said it.

Not even to herself completely.

Instead, she continued walking beside Aratrika.

Prangik noticed the change too.

One afternoon, he found Aratrika sitting on the library steps.

“You’ve started another notebook.”

She looked up.

“How did you know?”

“You carry it everywhere.”

She smiled.

“It’s different.”

“How?”

“This one isn’t only about me.”

Prangik looked at the notebook.

“What is it about?”

“People.”

“Which people?”

“The ones nobody notices.”

He was silent for a moment.

Then he said, “Maybe those are the stories that need to be written most.”

Aratrika looked at him.

“That’s what I think.”

She opened the notebook.

“I want to write something that makes people stop.”

“Stop what?”

“Just stop.”

She searched for the right words.

“Stop scrolling. Stop talking. Stop assuming. Stop deciding that someone else’s suffering is none of their concern.”

Prangik smiled.

“Then write it.”

“I will.”

He did not ask to read the notebook.

He had learned that some pages were hers alone.

Instead, he simply sat beside her.

For several minutes, neither spoke.

The silence was comfortable.

That evening, Aratrika began writing a series of short pieces.

She wrote about dignity.

Education.

Girls who were told to remain silent.

Families that confused control with protection.

Students whose abilities were overlooked.

People who had dreams but lacked opportunities.

She did not know whether anyone would read them.

She wrote anyway.

Krittika read some of them.

She sometimes disagreed.

Sometimes she argued with Aratrika for an hour.

“Not everyone will understand what you’re saying.”

“I know.”

“Then why write it?”

“Because understanding has to begin somewhere.”

Krittika had no answer.

She looked at her friend.

For a brief moment, she felt that strange mixture again.

Admiration.

Pride.

And something darker that she did not want to name.

Then she pushed it away.

“You’re impossible,” she said.

Aratrika laughed.

“That’s what you always say.”

At home, Mr. and Mrs. Saha watched their daughter changing.

Mr. Saha remained concerned about her future.

“Writing is fine,” he told her one evening, “but you need a stable career.”

“I know, Baba.”

“Promise me you won’t forget your studies.”

“I won’t.”

Mrs. Saha listened from the doorway.

She understood something her husband did not.

Aratrika was not abandoning her future.

She was trying to decide what kind of future she wanted.

Later that night, Aratrika opened the new notebook.

She wrote:

I once thought my words were meant to escape my room.

Now I think they are meant to enter places where I cannot go.

She paused.

Then she added:

Perhaps writing is not about becoming famous.

Perhaps it is about making someone feel less invisible.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the street was quiet.

Somewhere nearby, a child was still studying under a dim light.

Somewhere else, someone was being told that their dream was impossible.

Aratrika did not know their names.

Not yet.

But she had begun looking.

And once she began looking, she could no longer pretend she had not seen.

The girl who had once written only about her own feelings was beginning to write for people whose voices were rarely heard.

Her world was becoming larger.

And so were her words.

IV

The Country Hears

Chapter 15

The First Crowd

Aratrika's writing had begun to travel beyond her notebook.

At first, it was only within the school.

A teacher would read one of her pieces and recommend it to another teacher.

A student would copy a sentence into a personal notebook.

Someone would mention her writing during lunch.

Then a few of her articles appeared in the school magazine.

The response surprised her.

She had expected people to read them and move on.

Instead, some came to her with questions.

One student approached her after class.

“I read what you wrote about education.”

Aratrika looked up.

“Yes?”

“I thought you were writing about people who couldn't study.”

“I was.”

“My cousin had to leave school last year.”

Aratrika became quiet.

“I didn't know.”

“Neither did most people.”

The student walked away.

Aratrika remained standing in the corridor.

That evening, she opened her notebook.

She wrote:

Sometimes a story becomes real only when someone tells you, “That happened to me.”

She underlined the sentence.

She was beginning to understand that writing could do more than express an opinion.

It could make people recognize themselves.

It could make strangers recognize one another.

It could turn an invisible problem into something people could no longer ignore.

A few weeks later, the school organized a community discussion.

The subject was education and opportunity.

A teacher asked Aratrika to speak.

She almost refused.

Then she remembered the auditorium.

The microphone.

The trembling in her hands.

The first applause.

She accepted.

This time, the audience was different.

There were students, teachers, parents and several people from the surrounding community.

Aratrika stood at the front.

She looked at the crowd.

There were more people than she had ever addressed before.

For a moment, she remembered the girl she had been when her name was missing from the Student Cabinet list.

That girl had wanted to be chosen.

This girl wanted something different.

She wanted people to listen.

“Education is often described as a path,” she began.

“But a path is useful only when people are actually allowed to walk on it.”

The room became quiet.

She continued.

“We celebrate success stories. We celebrate students who score highly. We celebrate those who win competitions and receive certificates.”

She paused.

“But what about the student who never gets the chance to enter the competition?”

Someone in the audience shifted in their seat.

“What about the child who has ability but no books? The student who has ideas but no confidence? The girl who has ambition but is repeatedly told that her ambitions are unnecessary?”

Her voice became stronger.

“We cannot celebrate opportunity while ignoring the people who were never given one.”

When she finished, the applause was longer than before.

But Aratrika did not smile immediately.

She looked at the people in front of her.

She wondered how many had heard her words and how many had truly listened.

After the event, several people approached her.

One mother thanked her.

A teacher congratulated her.

A student asked whether she could read more of her writing.

Then an elderly man stopped in front of her.

“Young people usually speak about changing the world.”

Aratrika waited.

“You spoke about changing what is around you first.”

He smiled.

“Remember that.”

She nodded.

“I will.”

Krittika had been watching from the side.

When the crowd finally began to leave, she walked toward Aratrika.

“You were good.”

“Just good?”

“Very good.”

Aratrika laughed.

“You're impossible.”

Krittika smiled.

But behind the smile was something she did not express.

She was proud.

She truly was.

Yet every time people gathered around Aratrika, Krittika felt a small distance growing between them.

Aratrika was becoming someone people noticed.

Krittika wondered whether friendship could survive when one person began moving far beyond the world they had once shared.

She hated herself for thinking it.

So she said nothing.

Prangik approached them a few minutes later.

“You were nervous before going on stage.”

Aratrika looked surprised.

“You noticed?”

“You always tap your pen against your hand when you’re nervous.”

She smiled.

“I didn’t know I did that.”

“You do.”

Krittika looked between them.

“You two notice too much about each other.”

Aratrika laughed.

Prangik simply smiled.

They walked out of the building together.

The evening sky had turned orange.

Students were leaving through the school gates.

Aratrika stopped for a moment.

“What?”

Krittika asked.

“Nothing.”

She looked at the crowd.

“So many people.”

Krittika shrugged.

“That's what happens after an event.”

Aratrika shook her head.

“I don’t mean that.”

“What then?”

“I used to think writing was lonely.”

Prangik looked at her.

“Isn’t it?”

“Sometimes.”

She looked toward the people walking past.

“But maybe the writing is lonely only until someone reads it.”

Neither Krittika nor Prangik answered.

They simply continued walking.

That night, Aratrika received a message from a student she barely knew.

It contained only one sentence:

Your words made me want to continue studying.

Aratrika stared at the screen.

She read it several times.

Then she opened her notebook.

She wrote:

Today I learned something.

I cannot change everyone's life.

But perhaps I can change one person's tomorrow.

She closed the notebook.

The next morning, she began another piece.

This time, she did not write about herself.

She wrote about a girl who wanted to study but was repeatedly told that her dreams were unnecessary.

She gave the girl no name.

She gave her no extraordinary talent.

She simply gave her a voice.

When Aratrika finished, she read the final sentence.

Then she smiled.

The story was fictional.

But the problem was real.

And she knew that somewhere beyond the school walls, there were thousands of people whose stories had never been written.

She wanted to find them.

She wanted to listen.

She wanted to write.

The first crowd had gathered.

Aratrika did not know it yet, but the crowd would grow.

And with every new voice that joined hers, the girl who had once written alone in a hidden notebook would move one step closer to becoming a voice far larger than herself.

Chapter 16

The Country Hears

Aratrika's words began travelling farther than she had expected.

At first, her writing remained within the school.

Then it reached neighbouring schools.

A teacher submitted one of her essays to a youth magazine.

A student shared another with a community group.

Someone posted a photograph of one of her handwritten pages online.

Within weeks, strangers were reading words that Aratrika had once written alone at her desk.

She found it difficult to believe.

One evening, Mr. Saha came into her room holding a printed article.

“Is this yours?”

Aratrika looked up.

“Yes.”

“I found it in the newspaper.”

She took the paper from him.

Her name was printed beneath the title.

For several seconds, she simply stared at it.

Mrs. Saha entered the room.

“What happened?”

Mr. Saha held up the newspaper.

“Our daughter is in it.”

Mrs. Saha smiled.

Aratrika laughed.

“It’s only an article.”

Mr. Saha looked at her.

“Don’t say ‘only.’ You worked for it.”

She smiled.

For perhaps the first time, her father sounded less worried about her writing and more proud of it.

That night, Aratrika placed the newspaper beside her old notebook.

She wondered how strange it was that something written privately could eventually reach thousands of people.

But there was a difference between being read and being heard.

She wanted the latter.

Her writing became more focused.

She wrote about education.

About dignity.

About girls who were told their dreams were impractical.

About families who loved their children but sometimes mistook control for protection.

About students who were judged by marks before anyone asked what they wanted to become.

Her words became sharper.

Not cruel.

Just unwilling to look away.

People began inviting her to speak.

A school in another district invited her to address students.

Then a youth organisation asked her to participate in a discussion.

Later, she was invited to speak at a larger gathering.

Every time she travelled somewhere new, she carried the same old notebook.

Krittika teased her about it.

“You still carry that?”

Aratrika smiled.

“It has survived longer than some friendships.”

Krittika laughed.

“Very funny.”

But she knew the notebook mattered.

It contained the girl Aratrika had once been.

The girl who had felt invisible.

The girl who had cried beside the library window.

The girl who had wondered whether her words mattered.

Krittika sometimes wondered whether she herself was still part of that story.

She never asked.

Instead, she continued supporting Aratrika whenever she could.

Yet the feeling she had tried to ignore was still there.

It was not hatred.

It was not resentment.

It was something more uncomfortable.

She loved her friend.

But sometimes she wished the world would notice her too.

Aratrika never knew.

Prangik did not know either.

He was watching Aratrika's journey from a different distance.

He continued his studies.

He began thinking seriously about law.

Whenever Aratrika published something, he read it.

Whenever she spoke somewhere, he tried to attend if circumstances allowed.

He never wanted to become part of her public story.

He wanted to understand it.

One afternoon, he told her:

“You’re writing differently now.”

“How?”

“Earlier, you wrote because you had something to say.”

“And now?”

“Now you’re writing because other people have something they need someone to say for them.”

Aratrika became quiet.

“That sounds frightening.”

“It is.”

She smiled.

“Thank you for making it sound reassuring.”

Prangik laughed.

“I’m just telling you the truth.”

Aratrika looked at the old notebook in her hands.

“I don’t want people to think I speak for everyone.”

“Then don’t.”

“What should I do?”

“Listen first.”

She smiled.

“I already do.”

“I know.”

That conversation stayed with her.

She began spending more time listening to people before writing about their experiences.

She travelled to small communities.

She spoke with students.

She spoke with parents.

She listened to women whose stories had remained inside their homes for years.

She did not always agree with everyone.

She did not always have solutions.

But she wrote.

And people began responding.

A letter arrived from a student in another state.

Then another.

Then dozens.

Some thanked her.

Some disagreed with her.

Some told her their own stories.

One envelope contained a handwritten note:

I thought nobody would understand what I was going through. Then I read your article.

Aratrika read it twice.

She placed it carefully inside her diary.

She did not throw away any of the letters.

They became part of her private collection.

Years later, those letters would help others understand how far her words had travelled.

For now, Aratrika simply kept writing.

Her name began appearing in places she had never imagined.

She was invited to conferences.

Her essays were discussed by students.

Teachers recommended her writing.

People began describing her as a young voice of change.

Aratrika disliked the phrase.

“I am just writing,” she told Krittika.

Krittika smiled.

“That’s what everyone says before people start giving them titles.”

“I don’t want titles.”

“Then don’t collect them.”

“I won’t.”

But titles were not always something a person chose.

One evening, Aratrika stood before a large audience.

She looked at the rows of people.

Years earlier, she had been terrified of a school auditorium.

Now she could stand before hundreds without looking down.

She began speaking.

“I used to believe that words were fragile.”

The hall became silent.

“I thought they could disappear when the page was closed.”

She paused.

“But I was wrong.”

She looked across the audience.

“Words survive when people carry them.”

There was silence.

Then applause.

Aratrika smiled.

She did not know that those words would later become central to the way people remembered her.

She did not know that one day, her own words would be carried by people she could no longer meet.

That night, she returned home late.

Everyone was asleep.

She opened the old notebook.

Its pages were yellowing.

The binding was loose.

Some ink had faded.

She touched the first page.

She remembered the girl who had written there.

Then she turned to a new page.

She wrote:

My words have travelled farther than I ever expected.

She paused.

Then:

But I still feel like the girl sitting beside the window.

She smiled.

Another sentence followed.

Maybe that is important.

Because if I ever forget who I was, I may forget why I started writing.

She closed the notebook.

Outside, the city was quiet.

Somewhere beyond her room, beyond her school, beyond her neighbourhood, people were reading her words.

The country had begun to hear her.

But Aratrika still wrote as though nobody was listening.

That was what kept her honest.

And perhaps that was why people continued to listen.

Chapter 17

The Last Entry

The year had changed.

Aratrika's name was now familiar in places she had never visited.

Her articles were being read by students across the country. Invitations arrived regularly. Teachers introduced her as a young writer whose words had begun to reach beyond the classroom.

Yet whenever she returned home, she remained the same girl who preferred sitting beside the window with a notebook.

Fame had never been what she wanted.

She wanted her words to matter.

One evening, Prangik met her outside the library.

“You're leaving early today.”

“Yes.”

“Everything all right?”

“I'm tired.”

He nodded.

“You've been travelling a lot.”

“I know.”

“Then rest.”

Aratrika smiled.

“You sound like my mother.”

“That's probably a compliment.”

She laughed.

For a moment they stood quietly.

Then Prangik noticed the old notebook in her hand.

“You still use that?”

“Sometimes.”

“It's falling apart.”

“I know.”

“Get a new one.”

Aratrika looked at it.

“I have newer ones.”

“Then why keep this?”

She smiled.

“Because this one remembers who I was.”

Prangik did not argue.

He had learned that there were some things Aratrika would never explain completely.

That evening, she went home.

Mrs. Saha was waiting for her.

“You’re late.”

“I know. Sorry.”

“Have you eaten?”

“Not yet.”

Her mother brought her food.

For a while, they spoke about ordinary things.

School.

Family.

The next day's plans.

Nothing seemed unusual.

After dinner, Aratrika went to her room.

She opened her old diary.

Many pages had faded.

Some corners were folded.

Some sentences were barely visible.

She turned through the pages slowly.

There was the first writing competition.

The missing Student Cabinet name.

The first speech.

The 99% result.

The first letters from strangers.

The people whose stories she had promised to remember.

She reached a blank page.

For a long time, she simply held the pen.

Then she began.

I used to think words were meant to change the world.

She paused.

Now I think they are meant to change one person at a time.

She continued.

If someday nobody remembers my name, I hope somebody remembers what I was trying to say.

The room was silent.

She looked at the sentence.

Then wrote:

Do not let my words become decoration.

She stopped.

A final thought came to her.

Carry them.

She closed the diary.

That was the last entry she would ever write.

The following days brought confusion and grief to everyone who knew her.

Her family struggled to understand how suddenly their ordinary life had changed.

Her teachers spoke quietly in the corridors.

Students who had once heard her speeches gathered together and remembered her words.

Krittika could barely speak.

She kept thinking about the library.

The school auditorium.

The conversations beneath the tree.

The first time Aratrika had told her that a blank page could be a beginning.

Now there were no more conversations.

Only memories.

Krittika returned to the library alone.

She sat beside the familiar window.

For a long time, she looked at the empty chair opposite her.

She remembered Aratrika saying:

“Maybe being chosen isn’t the same as being heard.”

Krittika lowered her eyes.

She had once thought Aratrika’s words were simply words.

Now she understood that they had changed her.

They had made her question herself.

They had taught her to continue after disappointment.

They had shown her that failure did not have to become an ending.

But Krittika could not say any of this publicly.

Not yet.

There was something inside her that she did not understand.

She was proud of Aratrika.

She missed her.

She admired her.

And somewhere beneath all of that was a painful feeling she was ashamed to admit: sometimes she had been jealous of how naturally people gathered around Aratrika.

Even now, when Aratrika was gone, her words seemed to command more attention than anyone else's.

Krittika hated that thought.

So she kept it hidden.

Prangik responded differently.

He returned to the pages Aratrika had once allowed him to read.

He remembered her first speech.

Her questions.

Her determination.

Most of all, he remembered the simple truth behind everything she had written.

Words were meant to be carried.

He began searching for her writings.

Articles.

School magazine pieces.

Letters.

Speeches.

And, eventually, the old diary.

It was dusty.

Its cover was worn.

Several pages were fragile.

But the words remained.

Prangik read the final entry.

He reached the last line.

Carry them.

He closed the diary.

For several minutes, he said nothing.

Then he whispered:

“I will.”

Outside, the world continued.

People went to school.

Trains travelled between cities.

Newspapers printed new stories.

New students entered classrooms.

Life moved forward.

But in the hearts of the people who had known Aratrika, something remained unfinished.

Her story had ended.

Her words had not.

And perhaps that was the cruelest and most beautiful truth of all.

A person could disappear from the world.

A voice could fall silent.

A page could become old.

Ink could fade.

But words, once carried by another person, could begin a second life.

Aratrika had spent years writing because she feared being forgotten.

She had never realised that her words were already preparing themselves to survive her.

The diary remained closed that night.

But it would not remain hidden forever.

V

After the Words

Chapter 18

After Aratrika

The days after Aratrika's death seemed strangely ordinary.

The sun still rose.

The school bell still rang.

Teachers still entered classrooms carrying books.

Students still complained about homework.

But for the people who had known her, everything had changed.

Her desk remained empty.

Her name remained on old notebooks.

Her handwriting remained in the margins of library books.

And in the library, beside the familiar window, there was still the chair where she had spent countless afternoons writing.

Nobody wanted to move it.

Krittika returned there often.

Sometimes she sat for several minutes without opening a book.

She simply looked at the window.

She remembered the first time Aratrika had told her that a notebook could remember.

At the time, Krittika had laughed.

Now she understood.

A notebook really could remember.

It could remember a voice after the voice was gone.

It could remember dreams after the person who dreamed them could no longer speak.

One afternoon, Krittika found herself holding one of Aratrika's old articles.

She read it again.

Then again.

The words were familiar.

But they felt different now.

Before, they had been Aratrika's thoughts.

Now they felt like questions being asked directly to her.

What will you do with the opportunities you have?

Whose voice will you listen to?

What will you leave behind?

Krittika folded the paper carefully.

She did not have answers.

Not yet.

She only knew that she could not return to the person she had been before.

Aratrika had changed something inside her.

She had shown Krittika that disappointment did not have to become defeat.

That lesson became important in the years that followed.

Krittika faced setbacks of her own.

There were examinations she did not perform well in.

Plans that failed.

Opportunities that disappeared.

Moments when she wondered whether she was capable of moving forward.

Whenever that happened, she remembered Aratrika.

Not the public writer.

Not the girl whose name had appeared in newspapers.

She remembered the friend who had once sat beside her in the library and said:

“I’ll try again.”

Those three words became a quiet source of strength.

Krittika kept going.

She did not always succeed.

But she continued.

Meanwhile, Prangik carried Aratrika’s words differently.

He had begun studying law.

The years became busy.

Lectures.

Books.

Examinations.

Internships.

Cases.

Responsibilities.

There were days when he barely had time to think about the past.

But whenever he found himself close to giving up, he remembered the old notebook.

He remembered Aratrika's belief that words were meant to be carried.

He remembered her asking him whether a person could make a difference without having a position.

He remembered answering:

“Maybe.”

Years later, when he became a lawyer, he understood the question differently.

A position could give a person authority.

But words could give a person direction.

He never forgot that.

He began collecting everything he could find that Aratrika had written.

Her published articles.

School magazine pieces.

Letters.

Speeches.

Notes.

Photographs.

Even incomplete pages.

Some people told him he was holding on to the past.

He disagreed.

“This isn’t the past,” he said.

“It’s evidence of what she believed.”

At the Saha household, Aratrika’s room remained almost untouched.

Mrs. Saha sometimes entered simply to dust the shelves.

She would stop whenever she saw the empty chair.

Mr. Saha kept some of Aratrika's certificates in a folder.

Neither parent spoke about her constantly.

But both carried her absence.

One evening, Mrs. Saha found an old notebook inside a cupboard.

She opened it.

The handwriting was unmistakable.

She read several pages.

Then she closed it.

For the first time, she understood how much of her daughter she had never known.

Aratrika had not been hiding because she did not trust her family.

She had been writing because there were things she did not know how to say aloud.

Mrs. Saha placed the notebook back carefully.

She whispered:

“I wish I had asked.”

Years passed.

The school changed.

New students entered.

Old teachers retired.

The notice board where Aratrika's name had once been missing was replaced.

Almost nobody remembered the incident anymore.

But Kritika did.

Prangik did.

And the diary did.

That diary had survived everything.

Its pages had yellowed.

Its cover had become dusty.

Some ink had faded.

But the words remained.

One afternoon, Prangik finally found it again.

He had been searching through a box of Aratrika's belongings that had been stored away for years.

He lifted an old cloth-covered diary.

Dust covered the surface.

He wiped it gently.

Then he opened it.

The first pages were filled with familiar handwriting.

He kept reading.

The library.

The missing name.

The speech.

The 99%.

The stories of strangers.

The dreams.

The fears.

And finally, the last entry.

Prangik reached the final sentence.

Carry them.

He closed his eyes.

He remembered Aratrika telling him that she wanted her words to reach places where she could not.

Now he understood what she had meant.

She had not wanted a monument.

She had wanted her ideas to remain alive.

Prangik looked at the dusty diary again.

“No,” he whispered.

“This cannot remain in a box.”

He carefully placed it on the table.

For the first time in years, he began thinking beyond his own memories.

He began thinking about preservation.

About archives.

About libraries.

About national literary institutions.

About how a young writer's work could disappear if nobody protected it.

He knew that emotion alone would not be enough.

There would have to be documentation.

Legal procedures.

Authenticity.

Careful preservation.

Public recognition.

It would take years.

But Prangik had learned something from Aratrika.

A difficult task was not a reason to abandon it.

That evening, he opened a fresh file.

At the top of the first page, he wrote:

The Aratrika Saha Literary Archive.

He stared at the words.

Then he began.

Far away, Krittika was beginning a different journey.

She had entered public life.

She had begun working with people.

She had discovered that leadership was much harder than speeches made it sound.

Whenever she felt lost, she returned to one of Aratrika's old sentences.

She never told anyone where she had found it.

She never explained how much it meant to her.

Perhaps she was afraid that admitting the truth would make her feel smaller.

Perhaps she was afraid of how much she still missed her friend.

Or perhaps some memories were simply too personal to become public statements.

Whatever the reason, Krittika kept the truth inside herself.

Prangik chose a different path.

He decided that Aratrika's words should not belong only to those who had known her.

They belonged to everyone who could learn from them.

The two people Aratrika had influenced most deeply were now walking through separate lives.

One carried her words quietly.

The other carried them publicly.

Neither knew exactly where the journey would end.

But the diary had begun its own journey.

And its pages were waiting.

Chapter 19

The Diary

Years had passed since Aratrika's voice had fallen silent.

The world had changed around the people who remembered her.

Krittika had entered public life.

Her work took her from small meetings to larger responsibilities, from local concerns to matters that affected entire communities.

Eventually, she became the Chief Minister.

The position brought recognition, responsibility and pressure.

Every day came with files.

Every decision affected people she might never meet.

There were speeches to prepare and promises to fulfil.

Yet sometimes, late at night, when the official papers were finally closed, Krittika would remember a girl sitting beside a library window.

Aratrika.

The memory never arrived with ceremony.

It simply appeared.

A sentence.

A smile.

A disagreement.

A notebook.

And sometimes, the memory of the Student Cabinet list.

Krittika still remembered the empty space where Aratrika's name should have been.

She wondered how different everything might have been if that list had contained her name.

Then she would remember Aratrika's response.

I'll try again.

Those words had stayed with Krittika longer than she had ever admitted.

They had helped her through failures she had never spoken about publicly.

Whenever she lost an election for a position within an organisation, whenever a proposal she believed in was rejected, whenever someone told her that she was not ready, she remembered her friend.

She kept going.

But she never told anyone.

Not even the people closest to her knew how much of her determination came from a girl who had once shared a library with her.

Perhaps there was another reason for her silence.

Sometimes Kritika still felt a painful jealousy when she thought about Aratrika.

Even after all those years.

Aratrika had become a memory larger than the life she had actually lived.

People spoke about her writing.

Students quoted her.

Teachers remembered her speeches.

Her words continued to gather attention.

Krittika sometimes wondered whether she herself would ever leave such a mark.

She disliked the thought.

It made her feel disloyal.

So she buried it.

She decided that remembering Aratrika was enough.

Until Prangik came to her office.

He was no longer the boy who had once returned a pen in a school library.

He was now a lawyer.

He carried a carefully protected folder.

Krittika looked up from her desk.

“Prangik.”

He smiled.

“It has been a long time.”

“Yes.”

They shook hands.

For a moment, neither knew what to say.

Then Prangik placed the folder on the table.

“I found something.”

Krittika looked at it.

“What?”

“Her diary.”

Krittika froze.

For several seconds, she said nothing.

“Aratrika's?”

Prangik nodded.

“I found it among her old belongings.”

Krittika looked at the folder.

“Why are you bringing it to me?”

“Because I don't think it should remain private anymore.”

She looked at him.

“What do you mean?”

“I mean that her writing should be preserved properly.”

Krittika opened the folder.

Inside were photocopies and photographs of handwritten pages.

The handwriting was unmistakable.

She read the first page.

Then another.

Then another.

A sentence stopped her.

A list can decide where you stand in a room. It cannot decide how far you will walk after leaving that room.

She remembered the library.

She remembered saying those words to Aratrika.

Her eyes remained on the page.

Prangik spoke quietly.

“Her writing influenced people who never met her.”

“I know.”

“It influenced me.”

Krittika looked up.

He continued.

“It helped me continue when I wanted to give up. It made me believe that words could have consequences beyond the person who wrote them.”

Krittika lowered her eyes.

“She influenced me too.”

It was the first time she had said it aloud in years.

Prangik waited.

Krittika continued.

“When I failed, I remembered her.”

She gave a small smile.

“She always said she would try again.”

Prangik smiled.

“She meant it.”

Silence filled the room.

Krittika looked at the diary again.

“She wanted her words to reach people.”

“Yes.”

“Then what do you want to do?”

Prangik opened another document.

“I want to establish a permanent archive of her writings.”

Krittika listened.

“Her diary, published works, letters, speeches and surviving manuscripts. Properly preserved. Digitised. Documented.”

“And then?”

“I want the collection to be considered for national recognition as an important literary and cultural legacy.”

Krittika looked at him.

“You've thought about this carefully.”

“I have.”

“For how long?”

“Years.”

She turned another page.

The handwriting became smaller near the bottom.

Aratrika had written about people whose names she did not know.

People she wanted to help.

Dreams she wanted to continue.

Ideas she never had time to complete.

Krittika felt something tighten inside her.

She suddenly understood that the diary was not merely a record of Aratrika's life.

It was a record of a life that had wanted to become larger than itself.

“What would you need from me?” she asked.

“Nothing because you’re Chief Minister,” Prangik replied.

Krittika looked at him.

He continued.

“I need you to see this as Aratrika's work, not as a political project.”

The sentence surprised her.

Prangik closed the folder.

“If it is ever preserved nationally, it should be because the writings have value. Not because someone powerful happens to know her.”

Krittika nodded slowly.

“You're right.”

She looked once more at the diary.

For years, she had carried Aratrika's influence privately.

Now she had a choice.

She could continue keeping it hidden.

Or she could help ensure that other people discovered the words that had once helped her survive her own failures.

Krittika stood.

“I will support the process.”

Prangik smiled.

“Thank you.”

“But there is one thing.”

“What?”

“I don't want her remembered only because she died.”

Prangik looked at her carefully.

“I agree.”

“She should be remembered because she wrote.”

“Yes.”

“Because she questioned.”

“Yes.”

“Because she listened.”

Prangik nodded.

“And because she made people believe they could continue.”

Krittika looked at the diary.

“That should be the reason.”

Prangik picked up the folder.

“I’ll begin the formal process.”

Krittika nodded.

As he reached the door, she called him.

“Prangik.”

He turned.

“Did she ever know?”

“Know what?”

“How much her words meant to you?”

He was silent for a moment.

“Not completely.”

Krittika looked down.

“Neither did I.”

Prangik understood what she meant.

He did not ask her to explain.

Some truths were too complicated to be spoken in an office.

After he left, Krittika remained alone.

She opened the diary again.

Near the back, she found a page she had never seen before.

There were only a few lines.

If one day I am no longer here, do not make my absence the story.

Make the words the story.

Krittika read the lines again.

Then she closed the diary.

For the first time, she did not feel that preserving Aratrika's memory meant standing beneath her shadow.

Perhaps it meant helping her words stand on their own.

Outside the office, the city continued moving.

Inside, a dusty diary had begun a new chapter.

And somewhere between the pages of the past and the decisions of the present, Aratrika's voice was preparing to be heard again.

Chapter 20

Wilting of Words

The room was quiet when Prangik opened the final file.

It contained years of work.

Letters. Articles. Speeches. School notebooks. Photographs of handwritten pages. Newspaper clippings. Recordings of old speeches. Copies of essays that had once travelled from one classroom to another and then, somehow, across the country.

And at the centre of it all was the diary.

The same dusty diary that had once been hidden among old belongings.

The same diary in which a young girl had written because she did not know where else to put the things she felt.

Prangik looked at the first page.

The handwriting was unmistakably hers.

He had spent years working to make sure those pages would not disappear.

Not because Aratrika had become famous.

Not because she had once received ninety-nine percent.

Not because people now knew her name.

Because she had written.

Because she had questioned.

Because she had listened.

Because her words had made people believe that their own lives could contain something more than what others had decided for them.

The preservation process had taken time.

There were legal permissions, archival procedures, authentication of manuscripts, digitisation of documents, conservation of fragile paper, and discussions about where the collection should be kept.

Prangik had insisted that the original diary be preserved carefully.

He had also insisted that people should be able to read it.

A voice locked inside a box was safe.

But a voice read by someone was alive.

The final decision came quietly.

The collection would be preserved as part of a national literary and cultural heritage collection.

Aratrika's writings would be archived, documented and made available for students, researchers and readers.

The diary would be displayed under controlled archival conditions.

Prangik read the official document once.

Then again.

He closed his eyes.

For a moment, he could almost see the girl from the library.

The girl with the old notebook.

The girl who once refused to let him read a page.

The girl who eventually pushed one sheet across a table and trusted him with her words.

He remembered what she had once written.

Words survive when people carry them.

He had carried them.

Now others would too.

The day the diary was placed in the exhibition hall, there was no grand celebration.

There did not need to be one.

The diary rested behind protective glass.

Beside it was a simple description of Aratrika's life and work.

A photograph showed her sitting with a notebook in her hands.

Another displayed one of her handwritten pages.

There were no dramatic descriptions.

No attempt to turn her absence into entertainment.

The display spoke instead about a girl who began writing in a small room and gradually found a larger audience.

A girl who had once been left out of a school list.

A girl who had discovered that not being chosen did not mean being without purpose.

A girl who believed that education should open doors rather than become another wall.

A girl who wrote about dignity, opportunity, family expectations and the dreams of people who were often ignored.

Students began visiting.

Some came because their teachers had brought them.

Some came because they had heard the name.

Some knew nothing about her.

One afternoon, a group of schoolchildren stood in front of the diary.

One of them leaned closer to the glass.

"She was a student?" the girl asked.

"Yes," her teacher replied.

"Like us?"

"Yes. Like you."

The girl looked at the diary again.

She seemed surprised.

Perhaps that was the most important thing the exhibition could give her.

Aratrika had not begun as a monument.

She had begun as a girl.

A girl who had homework.

A girl who worried about examinations.

A girl who sometimes felt unheard.

A girl who kept a notebook beneath her mattress.

A girl who wrote because she had something inside her that demanded words.

Krittika stood at the back of the hall.

She had come without announcing the visit.

Years had passed since the two girls had sat together in a school library.

Now she was Chief Minister.

People knew her speeches.

They knew her decisions.

They knew her public achievements.

But nobody in the room knew everything she carried when she looked at that diary.

She remembered Aratrika's words during the years when Krittika herself had faced disappointment.

She remembered being told to continue.

She remembered being reminded that one failure could not become an entire life.

She remembered the strange, uncomfortable feeling that had sometimes followed Aratrika's success.

Pride.

Love for a friend.

And something else she had never been proud of.

Jealousy.

Aratrika's words had grown larger than either of them had imagined.

Sometimes Kritika had wondered whether there would always be a shadow beside her own achievements.

But standing there now, she understood something she had not understood when they were young.

A friend's light did not have to make her own disappear.

She looked at the diary.

"I carried your words too," she whispered.

Nobody heard her.

She was glad.

Some things did not need an audience.

Prangik joined her a few minutes later.

They stood silently.

"She would have hated a display that made her death the main story,"
Krittika said.

Prangik looked at the diary.

"That's why I fought for the words."

Krittika nodded.

"You knew what she wanted."

"I knew what she wrote."

They stood there for another moment.

Then Prangik pointed towards the final page.

It had been reproduced beside the diary.

The handwriting was slightly uneven.

The words were simple.

If one day I am no longer here, do not make my absence the story.

Make the words the story.

Krittika read it again.

This time, she did not look away.

Outside the hall, another group of students entered.

One of them carried a notebook.

She stopped in front of the diary.

She read the description.

Then she looked at the handwritten page.

She opened her own notebook.

Prangik noticed.

He smiled quietly.

He did not approach her.

He did not ask what she was writing.

He understood that some pages should be allowed to belong entirely to the person writing them.

The museum slowly filled with people.

Some read silently.

Some discussed the essays.

Some copied down thoughts.

Some simply stood before the old diary.

And somewhere, perhaps in another small room, another young person began writing something that had not yet found a reader.

That was how words continued.

Not all at once.

Not through grand speeches.

Not through monuments.

One page.

One reader.

One person carrying an idea into another day.

The diary had once been dusty.

The words inside it had once seemed forgotten.

But forgotten did not always mean finished.

Sometimes words wilted.

They faded from conversations.

They disappeared beneath years of silence.

They gathered dust.

Yet if even one person picked them up again, they could live.

Aratrika had spent her life believing that words mattered.

In the end, others proved her right.

Prangik had carried them into the law.

Krittika had carried them into public life.

Readers carried them into classrooms, homes and conversations.

Students carried them into notebooks.

And perhaps one day, one of those students would write something that Aratrika herself had never imagined.

The museum lights dimmed as evening approached.

The diary remained behind the glass.

Its pages were old.

Its edges were worn.

Its ink had softened with time.

But the words remained.

For a long time, people had believed that words could wilt.

They were right.

Words could wilt.

They could be ignored.

They could be forgotten.

They could disappear beneath silence.

But words, unlike flowers, did not always die when they wilted.

Sometimes they became seeds.

And sometimes, if someone cared enough to carry them, they found another place to grow.

Aratrika's name was no longer missing from a list.

It was written where thousands could see it.

But that was not what mattered most.

What mattered was that somewhere, a student was reading.

Somewhere, someone who had been told to remain silent was beginning to write.

Somewhere, someone who had failed was beginning again.

Somewhere, someone who felt unseen was discovering that their voice had value.

And somewhere, a blank page was waiting.

The diary remained still.

The museum became quiet.

The last visitor walked away.

But the words did not.

They had already begun another chapter.

And this time, they did not belong to Aratrika alone.

They belonged to everyone who chose to carry them.

Wilting of Words.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Pratyay Saha is a young writer, poet, and speaker with a deep interest in literature, academics, debating, and the power of language.

His writing is shaped by a particular fascination with the inner world of young people—their dreams, expectations, disappointments, and the words they sometimes struggle to express aloud. His work often explores how language can preserve experiences and give a voice to those who feel unheard.

He is the author of *Wilting of Words* and *Poetropodia*, and has also written works exploring poetry, language, identity, and society.

Through his writing, Pratyay seeks to uphold the spirit of his mother tongue and celebrate the lasting relationship between language and human expression.

He continues to write poetry and fiction while pursuing his academic journey and exploring new forms of storytelling.

Wilting of Words is his reflection on one simple idea:

Words may wilt, but they do not necessarily disappear.